

MUDDLE OF HONOUR



A.B. VAJPAYEE

His name was proposed by Advani. UPA retorted that Advani wanted to formalise his retirement.



JYOTI BASU

Congress propped his name to counter Vajpayee, taking even the communists by surprise.



KANSHI RAM

As with most of her demands, Mayawati wants this too for "Dalit pride". The national honour fits in with her national plans.



■ Priya Sahgal

It is supposed to be the country's greatest civilian honour, India's jewel, and yet today's politicians have reduced the Bharat Ratna to a bargain basement trophy. In the last 54 years, only 40 people have been awarded Bharat Ratna. But this year, in less than a week, over a dozen names have been lobbied towards 7, Race Course Road. Of these, 10 are politicians. If BJP wanted it for Atal Bihari Vajpayee; then the Congress quickly scouted its allies for a worthy octogenarian to counter the saffron claim and fielded CPI(M) patriarch Jyoti Basu's name, taking even the communists by surprise. Not to be left out, Mayawati played the Dalit card and demanded the award for her mentor, late Kanshi Ram.

Barely had her letter reached the prime minister's residence that another Dalit leader Ram Vilas Paswan countered her claim with a Dalit icon of his own. He immediately held a press conference in the Capital announcing that he rated Babu Jagjivan Ram "higher" than the other Ram for this award. Paswan also added singer

Mohammad Rafi and social worker Jyotiba Phule to his list so that it wouldn't be seen as a reaction to Mayawati's demand. He also had another ingenious suggestion: to give the Ratna posthumously so that a person's entire life could be taken into account.

It's a circus out there. It was Opposition leader L.K. Advani who started this canonise-my-candidate war by proposing Vajpayee's name on January 5. He then released the letter to the media five days later and, thus, began the race for the Ratna. It was to counter Vajpayee's name that Congress media chairperson Veerappa Moily suggested that there were other names that could be considered such as Basu. When CPI(M) retorted by saying that it was against lobbying for awards and CPI added that it did not believe in state awards, Congress finally blamed it all on BJP. "Advani must take the responsibility for initiating the trivialisation of the Bharat Ratna. By throwing it in the public domain, he has evoked competitive bidding," said party spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi.

RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav has questioned Advani's motives for sug-

gesting Vajpayee's name, saying that "Advani spoilt Vajpayee's chances by writing this letter. He wants to formalise and finalise his retirement, which is why he suggested his name." For his part, Lalu said he supported Basu's candidature as he still regards Vajpayee as BJP's prime ministerial candidate, and not Advani.

The saffron party, however, begs to differ. According to an Advani loyalist the reason for publicising the letter was simply to put pressure on the UPA Government by bringing Vajpayee's name in the public domain. "Vajpayee is head-and-shoulders above everybody else. The Government should have given him a Bharat Ratna during the three years it has been in power. It is good that there is now a national debate on this," says Sudheendra Kulkarni, a former BJP secretary. Another party general secretary adds, "If the proposal had been in a private letter, would the Government have ever considered Vajpayee?"

Unlike the Padma awards where the decision is taken by a screening committee, the Ratna awards are the prerogative of the prime minister.